

Section 1: Management of Mild Upper Respiratory Symptoms

The common cold and mild upper respiratory tract infections are typically viral self-limiting illnesses lasting 7 to 10 days.

Recommended Self-Care Actions: 1. Rest: Ample physical rest allows the immune system to recover efficiently. 2. Fluid Intake: Drink warm fluids such as warm water, herbal teas, or clear broth to soothe inflamed airways and maintain hydration. 3. Steam Inhalation & Moist Air: Warm steam or a cool-mist humidifier helps loosen nasal secretions and ease breathing. 4. Saline Nasal Rinses: Sterile saline sprays or rinses help reduce nasal congestion safely.

Safety Exclusions: Antibiotics are ineffective against viral respiratory infections and should never be used without a physician's prescription.

Section 2: Respiratory Red Flags and Medical Escalation

Red Flag Symptoms Requiring Immediate Medical Attention: - Difficulty breathing, wheezing, or shortness of breath. - Persistent high fever ($>38.5^{\circ}\text{C}$ or 101.3°F) lasting more than 3 days. - Chest pain or pressure during breathing or coughing. - Coughing up blood or thick discolored sputum. - Bluish lips or face (cyanosis).

Special Considerations: Children, elderly individuals, and adults with asthma or COPD should seek early medical advice for respiratory symptoms.

Section 3: Sore Throat & Cough Relief Interventions

Mild cough and throat irritation can be managed with non-pharmacological comfort steps. Supportive Care Measures:

- Warm Salt Water Gargle: Dissolve 1/2 teaspoon of salt in warm water and gargle 2-3 times daily to relieve throat soreness.
- Honey (for adults and children over 1 year): 1-2 teaspoons of natural honey can soothe cough fits. Never give honey to infants under 1 year due to botulism risk.
- Elevating the Head: Use an extra pillow during sleep to reduce nighttime coughing caused by post-nasal drip.

Section 4: Infection Control & Hygiene Guidelines

Preventing the spread of upper respiratory viruses protects family and community health. Key Prevention Steps: - Cover coughs and sneezes with a elbow or tissue. - Wash hands thoroughly with soap and water after coughing or sneezing. - Avoid close contact with vulnerable individuals during acute respiratory symptoms.